

***Lou Reed: The King of New York.*** By Will Hermes. NY: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2023. 529pp (hardback). ISBN: 978-0-3741-9339-3

From his most tender, poetic moments as a wordsmith and poet, to his lowest as a chauvinistic egoist, *Lou Reed: The King of New York* walks readers through the wild side of Lewis Allan Reed's life—a life riddled with dustups, bruises, veins, and needles. Will Hermes' biography is as sprawling and layered as Reed's own career, and it captures the full arc of the man: a groundbreaking songwriter whose complicated life changed him just as much as his music changed. This biography complicates the stereotypical "badboy" Rockstar image of Lou Reed as an unapologetic provocateur, instead adding dimensionality and context to his life and persona.

The book is as comprehensive as it is readable. Structured chronologically, it traces Reed's journey from his youth on Long Island in the 1950s through his final revered years as one of the progenitors of American art rock. Hermes not only documents the facts of Reed's life—birth, death, records, tours—but immerses us in the cultural, musical, and personal contexts that shaped those moments. Album releases are interwoven with scenes from Warhol's "Factory," recording studios, and performance venues, while he examines personal crises not as tabloid gossip but as windows into Reed's complex psychology and artistic evolution. For example, as documented by Victor Bockris (in *Transformer: The Lou Reed Story* (Simon & Schuster, 1994)) and echoed by later biographers, Reed allegedly slapped David Bowie during a dinner in New York. Hermes recounts this incident as the result of Reed's struggle with addiction: Bowie would be willing to produce another one of Reed's albums if Reed "[cleaned] up his act" (in reference to his drug and alcohol use). Reed's actions, which are still not condoned by the author, are situated within the setting of an ongoing drug problem and Reed's sensitivity to criticism.

One of Hermes' great strengths lies in the way he places Reed within a web of artistic and social relationships. The book features extended biographical sketches on key figures such as John Cale, Andy Warhol, Sterling Morrison, Moe Tucker, Laurie Anderson, and others. These portraits are not digressions but essential nodes in the story, allowing readers to understand *their* work as part of a broader cultural influence, and understand Reed's work within a shifting musical landscape. In describing the creation of The Velvet Underground & Nico, Hermes gives space to Cale's background with avant-garde composers like La Monte Young and John Cage, as well as Warhol's influence as both patron and an evocative queer iconographer. These connections offer not only context but insight: Reed's lyrical daring and sonic risk-taking come into sharper focus when situated alongside such boundary-pushing collaborators.

Hermes also anchors Reed's story in the social and political climate of the times. Events like the Stonewall uprising, the AIDS crisis, and Reagan-era politics, all powerfully affect Reed's music. This approach highlights how Reed's music, especially his queerness and drug references, intersected with real social struggle and visibility. For example, Reed's most famous track, "Walk on the Wild Side," is not just a pop oddity—it is a prism through which the queered subcultures of Warhol's Factory and downtown New York are refracted into the mainstream. Hermes makes sure we understand that.

This attention to historical and cultural detail is what sets *The King of New York* apart from previous Reed biographies. One doesn't need to be a Lou Reed devotee to appreciate

the book; in fact, it serves just as effectively as a history of American underground music from the 1960s through the early 2000s. Hermes gives ample attention to Reed's lesser-known projects—albums like *The Blue Mask* or *Songs for Drella*—and contextualizes them in terms of critical reception, personal upheaval, and technical production. Reed's battles with RCA executives, his complex relationship with bandmates, and his often-combative press persona are all presented with nuance rather than sensationalism.

What makes this such an absorbing read is Hermes' ability to balance journalistic clarity with a literary touch. He's a seasoned critic (with bylines in *Rolling Stone*, *The New York Times*, and NPR), and his prose is clear, well-paced, and moving. Descriptions of concerts are vivid and energetic, and moments of interpersonal conflicts rendered without exaggeration. For example, in discussing Reed's 1974 *Sally Can't Dance* tour, Hermes details not just the drug-fueled chaos but the loneliness and insecurity that seemed to drive it—a far cry from the macho nihilism often projected onto Reed's persona.

The research is deep for the book, drawing on archival interviews, critical reviews, personal letters, and dozens of new conversations with those who knew or worked with Reed. Hermes makes extensive use of the New York Public Library's Library for the Performing Arts, which houses the Lou Reed Archive in addition to collections from Cornell University, the Harry Ransom Center, and the Andy Warhol Museum. In an interview with Andrew Holter ("Electricity In, Electricity Out: A Conversation with Will Hermes," *Los Angeles Review of Books*, December 3, 2023), Hermes recounts spending "more than the whole summer of 2019 ... for multiple days a week just turning every page" in the Library for the Performing Arts, and it shows. I imagine that these interviews are of specific interest to the ARSC readership.

As a result of the thorough research, the book is long, and readers may be intimidated by its length (nearly 450 pages of text, plus extensive notes and references); with some biographies a reader can skip between sections, but I believe that in order to fully experience the book, it should be read in order, cover-to-cover; Hermes's rich coloring of characters and environment make it difficult for a reader to "jump around" the book without missing essential context. However, despite the length, Hermes makes the journey feel brisk and continually rewarding. This is in part due to the innately compelling nature of Reed's life, and to Hermes' skill as a storyteller. Each chapter flows naturally into the next, and even the more technical sections—on mastering techniques, for instance, or recording setups—are presented in an accessible, engaging style.

For scholars of recorded sound, *The King of New York* offers valuable insights not only into Reed's discography but also into the broader production ecosystems of his time. The book details how albums were financed, produced, mixed, and received. Hermes even includes discussions of bootlegs, rare pressings, and archival materials, making it of particular interest to the ARSC community.

In short, *King of New York* is a triumph of biography. It neither lionizes nor condemns its subject but instead proffers a humble and detailed biome surrounding Reed and his music. As the author states, "[if] you're hoping for some neat totalizing statement or psychological profile to explain Reed... you won't find it here... [Reed] represented the potentialities of identity, one reason why he remains such a compelling figure" (p.1). By the end, we feel closer to the real Lou Reed—not the myth or caricature, but the restless, searching artist we owe for so much American music. *Reviewed by Matt Chiu*